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Perspectives of Artificial Intelligence Use for In-House Ethics Checks of Journal Submissions

Fatima Alnaimat,[1] **Abdel Rahman Feras AlSamhori**,[2] **Omar Hamdan**,[2] **Birzhan Seiil**,[3] **and Ainur B. Qumar**[4]

[1]Division of Rheumatology, Department of Internal Medicine, School of Medicine, University of Jordan, Amman, Jordan
[2]School of Medicine, University of Jordan, Amman, Jordan
[3]Department of Chemical Disciplines, Biology and Biochemistry, South Kazakhstan Medical Academy, Shymkent, Kazakhstan
[4]Department of Health Policy and Management, Asfendiyarov Kazakh National Medical University, Almaty, Kazakhstan

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Address for Correspondence:
Fatima Alnaimat, MD
Division of Rheumatology, Department of Internal Medicine, School of Medicine, University of Jordan, Queen Rania St, Amman 11942, Jordan.
Email: f.naimat@ju.edu.jo

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ORCID iDs
Fatima Alnaimat
https://orcid.org/0000-0002-5574-2939
Abdel Rahman Feras AlSamhori
https://orcid.org/0000-0002-2715-4320
Omar Hamdan
https://orcid.org/0009-0008-0442-0578
Birzhan Seiil
https://orcid.org/0000-0003-1524-8888
Ainur B. Qumar
https://orcid.org/0000-0003-0457-7205

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ABSTRACT

Artificial intelligence (AI) has shown its ability to transform academic writing and publishing. It offers significant benefits, including enhancing efficiency, consistency, and integrity, However, these advancements are accompanied by ethical concerns (particularly around authorship, originality, and transparency) and the need for human oversight in peer review and editorial processes. In this study we explore AI for ethics checks in journal submissions. Specific AI platforms—such as YesChat for bias detection, Turnitin's iThenticate for plagiarism, Proofig for image integrity, and GPTZero for AI-generated content—can identify ethical breaches through tailored prompts and queries. Additionally, AI is increasingly used to detect missing or vague ethics statements, conflicts of interest, and citation manipulation by analyzing structured text and databases. AI-enhanced tools like Elsevier's Editorial Manager and Enago Read assist in ensuring compliance with journal-specific ethical guidelines and streamline peer review. Moreover, emerging algorithms, such as CIDRE, have shown promise in identifying abnormal citation behaviors. As AI accuracy improves, these platforms are expected to be integrated directly into submission systems, enhancing research integrity, transparency, and accountability.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence; Academic Publishing; Ethics; Peer Review; Authorship

INTRODUCTION

Artificial intelligence (AI) has changed many aspects of our lives, from healthcare to entertainment.[1] Using AI has revolutionized academic writing by handling complex ideas and large amounts of information, in a addition to enhancing writing in multiple domains.[2,3] Also, AI has revolutionized academic writing by handling complex ideas and extensive information as it can enhance academic writing in multiple domains (idea development and research design, content development and structuring, literature review and synthesis, data management and analysis, editing, review, and publishing support and communication, outreach, and ethical compliance).[4-8] These tools are helpful to improve the effectiveness and

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Disclosure of AI Use

Grammarly (https://app.grammarly.com/) was utilized to enhance the grammar and clarity of this manuscript. All authors have reviewed AI edits and revised them multiple times.

Author Contributions

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quality of academic writing. They help writers to focus on the critical and novel aspects of their research.[4,9] Nowadays, journals and publishers are beginning to use AI tools,[10] to benefit from their abilities to address a range of issues, from plagiarism and data manipulation to possible conflicts of interest.[11] The coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19) pandemic demonstrated the importance of quick and thorough ethics review processes.[12] The Research Ethics Committee's goals, methods, and processes must be adjusted due to the extraordinary expansion of research investigations and associated ethical submissions.[13] The integrity of submitted research papers is probably to be improved by using AI tools to check plagiarism and data manipulation, but this also raises some ethical issues and concerns, such as bias and privacy issues.[11,14,15]

The capacity of AI to improve consistency, efficiency, and cost-effectiveness has led to a growing integration of AI in academic work by researchers worldwide.[16] These tools can also handle a large amount of data, as they can comprehend the context of a query and exclude irrelevant articles, ensuring that researchers receive the most relevant findings.[5] This can save time and ensure that crucial papers are not missed or overlooked.[5,16]

One potential disadvantage of using AI in peer review is becoming too dependent on it. Peer review quality may suffer if editors and reviewers rely too much on AI-generated content.[17] In domains where human proficiency is essential, excessive dependence on AI might result in errors or inadequate assessments of significant manuscript components.[18] Reviewers must carefully evaluate AI-generated information to ensure that the final decisions respect accurate, in-depth examination.[19]

The strengths of employing AI for In-house checks can be demonstrated in multiple ways; first, AI greatly improves productivity, which saves a lot of time during the reviewer selection process.[20] Second, it can help find reviewers outside the editor's immediate network, expanding the reviewer pool.[20] Third, by using the same standards, AI makes sure that all papers are consistent and relevant to the research topic.[20] Fourth, potential problems, such as plagiarism, statistical inaccuracies, or methodological mistakes, could be identified by AI before entering the peer review process. The editorial workflow's overall effectiveness will increase when ensuring only high-quality manuscripts are moved on to human review.[21]

The aim of this article is to examine how AI may be included in editing procedures, with a focus on how it can be used to carry out internal ethical reviews for journal submissions. This study explores how AI tools—such as plagiarism detectors, bias analyzers, and image integrity checkers—might improve the editing process by spotting ethical issues before peer review. It looks at AI's potential to ease the editorial load in high-volume publishing settings, facilitate consistent adherence to ethical publishing standards, and accelerate article review. This study provides useful insights to journal editors and publishers looking to maintain research integrity and raise the standard of academic publications by assessing current AI-driven platforms and practices.

WHICH SPECIFIC AI PLATFORMS CAN BE EMPLOYED FOR ETHICS EVALUATIONS IN MANUSCRIPTS? ROLE OF SPECIFIC QUESTIONS AND PROMPTS

To detect common ethical problems in research (e.g., conflict of interest, biases, data integrity), AI can be used to perform such a task using language processing and machine learning.[22]

Table 1. AI tools that can be used for ethical revision of scientific articles and function of queries and prompts

AI tool	Ethics evaluation	Specific questions and prompts
Bias detector: yeschat.ai[23]	The purpose of the Bias Detector is to analyze text to detect and evaluate biases. The detection of bias, including its type, degree, and direction, is achieved by providing a summary of the key points and ideas presented in the text, followed by identifying sections that may have been biased. These results are incorporated into a comprehensive analysis of the text's overall net bias in the final product. This service is particularly helpful in settings such as academic research and policy development, where awareness of bias is crucial. A journalist, for example, may use Bias Detector to assess the impartiality of a news article and ensure it does not unnecessarily favor one political viewpoint over another.[24]	"Does the manuscript avoid biased language that could influence the interpretation of results?" or "Does the research design consider all relevant populations?"[23]
Plagiarism Detector: Originality.AI[25]	Originality.AI is a tool for checking for plagiarism and identifying AI-generated material.[26] It delivers an easy-to-use AI Plagiarism Checker, Readability Score Checker, and Fact Checking Aid using machine learning methods.[25] It assesses if plagiarism is present and whether AI authorship is likely by looking at writing patterns and comparing the document to databases of published work.[25,26]	"Check this text for plagiarism and AI-generated material. Emphasize any text that matches, mark passages that might not have been written by a human, and provide an originality score."[25,26]
AI-Generated Content Detecting: GPTZero, Scribbr AI detector[27,28]	AI detectors can be used to identify when a piece of writing is most likely to have been produced by AI. Moderators attempting to eliminate spam and phony product reviews may find this helpful, as would teachers who wish to ensure that their students are writing independently.[29] However, with a high (35%) false-negative rate, GPTZero frequently fails to detect machine-generated text and mistakenly labels it as human-written yet having a comparatively low false-positive (10%) rate, which means it rarely misclassifies human-written material as AI-generated.[30]	"Analyze this text for AI-generated content. Identify any sections that may have been written using AI and provide a probability score for AI authorship."[27,28]
AI-Integrated Journal Submission Platforms: Elsevier's Editorial Manager[31] and AIRA[32]	By automating ethical compliance checks, AI-integrated journal submission platforms are transforming the manuscript review process, improving research integrity and expediting editorial operations.[33] AIRA, has been developed by Frontiers journals, uses AI to automatically check for ethical compliance, identify issues in image quality (such as possible duplications or manipulations), evaluate the consistency of reported research methods, and assess the manuscript's structure and language clarity.[34]	"Please confirm that your study has received approval from the appropriate ethics committee and that informed consent was obtained from all participants."[32]
AI Image Detector: Proofig[35]	AI checks pictures for modification, including duplication to maintain the integrity of the study. By guarantees the highest levels of ethics, quality, and integrity of image.[36]	"Have all images in this manuscript been checked for duplication or manipulation? Please confirm that the figures are original and upload the Proofig integrity report if available."[35]

AI = artificial intelligence, AIRA = Artificial Intelligence Review Assistant.

Examples of AI tools that can be used for ethical revision of scientific articles, in addition to the function of queries and prompts they might employ are presented in the **Table 1**.[23-36]

AI FOR DETECTING MISSING RESEARCH ETHICS STATEMENTS

The absence or ambiguity of ethical declarations in article submissions is a frequent ethical problem.[37] This may occur for a few reasons. Ethics statements are sometimes unintentionally missed by writers, particularly in retrospective research.[37-39] The absence of comparable protocols in publications may lead to uneven reporting of ethical clearances.[40,41] Additionally, researchers sometimes use unclear phrases, such as "Ethical approval was obtained," without mentioning the organization's name or approval number.[37,39]

To date, scientific committees worldwide have continuously developed methods aimed at achieving transparency in research, including informed consent, Institutional Review Board (IRB) approvals, and data privacy regulations.[42,43] Currently, there is a notable increase in the use of AI to identify ethical anomalies in scientific research and to preserve research integrity, such as its use in identifying academic papers that lack research ethics statements.[44] In addition to the current methods for protecting the ethical integrity of published research, AI can be considered an extra layer of defense to ensure even better protection.[45] However, either unintentionally or due to error, these statements can be missed.[46] To ensure that such

errors do not happen, AI can play an important role in reviewing research articles for the presence of these ethics statements, which will strengthen adherence to established research ethics guidelines.[46]

As the accuracy of AI tools is improving, their role in scientific research ethics detection is expanding as well. AI is currently able to detect potential conflicts of interest by analyzing data from funding agencies, publishing databases, and institutional records.[46] By comparing this data, AI may identify connections and overlaps that might not be immediately apparent.[46] One example of how AI can improve the ethical integrity of research papers is by detecting conflicts of interest between researchers and other funding organizations. The authors might not report these conflicts, but still, AI tools will be able to detect such issues.[46] Its ability to perform comprehensive and accurate identifications of conflicts of interest is what makes AI superior to other conventional methods.[46]

AI tools can be trained using research papers, and it is expected that its ability to detect any anomalies regarding the ethics statement will continue to improve given the current large number of already published research papers.[47] Based on all of these facts, it is expected that in the near future, submitted papers may be automatically screened by AI tools utilizing machine learning techniques before submission.[48] Multiple submission platforms may integrate AI into their submission system to ensure that manuscripts meet ethical reporting standards before they are sent to peer reviewers.[4,49] This action will result in improving the quality of research and decreasing the number of published research papers with suboptimal ethics statements and approvals, which will lead to the improvement of research transparency in general.[49,50] AI can help identify missing ethics statements by using text analysis and natural language processing (NLP).[51] AI works by scanning research papers for phrases, keywords, or structured sentences that signify informed consent or ethical approval and compares them to databases of properly prepared ethical declarations.[52,53]

Additionally, the process of identifying missing ethics statements can be strengthened by AI-assisted peer review, as Enago Read.[54,55] These systems compare a manuscript's ethical statements and the guidelines of the journal of interest, followed by providing recommendations for either correction or revision if necessary, which can improve the reviewers' efficiency.[54] However, there are a number of problems with research misconduct that arise from the use of AI-assisted peer review approaches, such as the addition of fake citations or language that has been plagiarized from another source.[56]

AI FOR DETECTING CITATION MANIPULATIONS AND INAPPROPRIATE REFERENCES

Citation manipulation and inappropriate referencing

The main goal of citing in academic writing is to acknowledge colleagues' work, which arises from the fact that scientists build on previous knowledge to explore new aspects of human knowledge.[57] In academic writing, citations have become a measure of success; the higher the number of citations, the better it is for journals and scientists.[58] Citation-based measures, including h-index and journal impact factor, are considered the mainstay of evaluating journals, scientists, and their published papers.[59,60] These measures are also utilized when scientists are competing for limited resources, such as grants.[61]

Citation manipulation is defined as the practice of falsely citing references that were neither used nor relevant to the manuscript's content, and that do not support the information provided, with the intent of increasing the number of citations.[62,63] Intentional citation manipulation is a form of scientific and academic misconduct. However, false citations can sometimes be unintentional due to human errors, such as typographical mistakes. In cases where it is intentional, it is considered academic misconduct.[64]

AI tools for citation analysis

There is limited data in the academic literature on the effectiveness of AI in detecting citation manipulation and inappropriate references utilized by journals. However, some algorithms were developed to identify anomalous citation behaviors, including the CIDRE algorithm, which was designed to detect abnormal citation behavior between journals and was successful in detecting anomalous groups of journals where the abnormal citation behaviors led to an increase in the journals' impact factor.[65] Reference Check is an available tool provided by Scite that analyses manuscripts in terms of how a given manuscript cites its own references and checks whether one of the references has received an editorial check.[66] Some journals also utilize reference-checking services, which can provide editors and reviewers with a list of references.[67]

AI for detecting authorship and conflict of interest issues

Authorship and conflict of interest issues

Authors are people who made a substantial contribution to the work and take responsibility for the published work.[67] There are multiple concerns regarding authorship listing in published academic work, which has led to the use of various terms to describe undeserved authorship, including honorary gifts and guest authorship. Many writers believe that these phrases are similar despite minor differences in their meanings because they all refer to the assignment of authorship to those who do not have significant intellectual contributions.[68] Gift authorship is offered to someone in the hope that they will return the favor.[69] Whereas honorary authorship is someone who was named an author because they hold a senior position in the institution where the research took place.[70] Whereas guest authors are senior authors whose presence can increase the chances of publication and the impact of the paper once published.[69]

A conflict of interest is when an individual with responsibilities toward others, including professional duties, may be influenced, whether consciously or unconsciously, by personal or financial interests. The presence of a conflict of interest does not always imply wrongdoing; rather, it refers to a situation where external factors have the potential to affect one's decisions or actions.[71] The effect of conflict of interest is evident in what is called the funding effect, where industry-funded trials are more likely to yield statistically significant results that are consistent with the sponsor's interest compared to studies funded by non-profit organizations.[72]

AI tools for authorship and conflict of interest detection

Currently, there are AI-operated tools that can detect authors through *stylometry,* which is the statistical analysis of the writing style.[73] Since *stylometry* involves analyzing a large number of texts, recognizing different patterns and writing styles, and examining the organization of a given text, AI-operated tools are well-suited for this task.[73] Multiple stylometric analysis models have been developed to detect authors' attribution using different textual features, including grammar,[74] which can yield an accuracy ranging from 60% to 98% in different populations and text sizes.[74-76] To date, there is a paucity of studies that explore the application of these tools in academic journals. However, there are currently some tools that

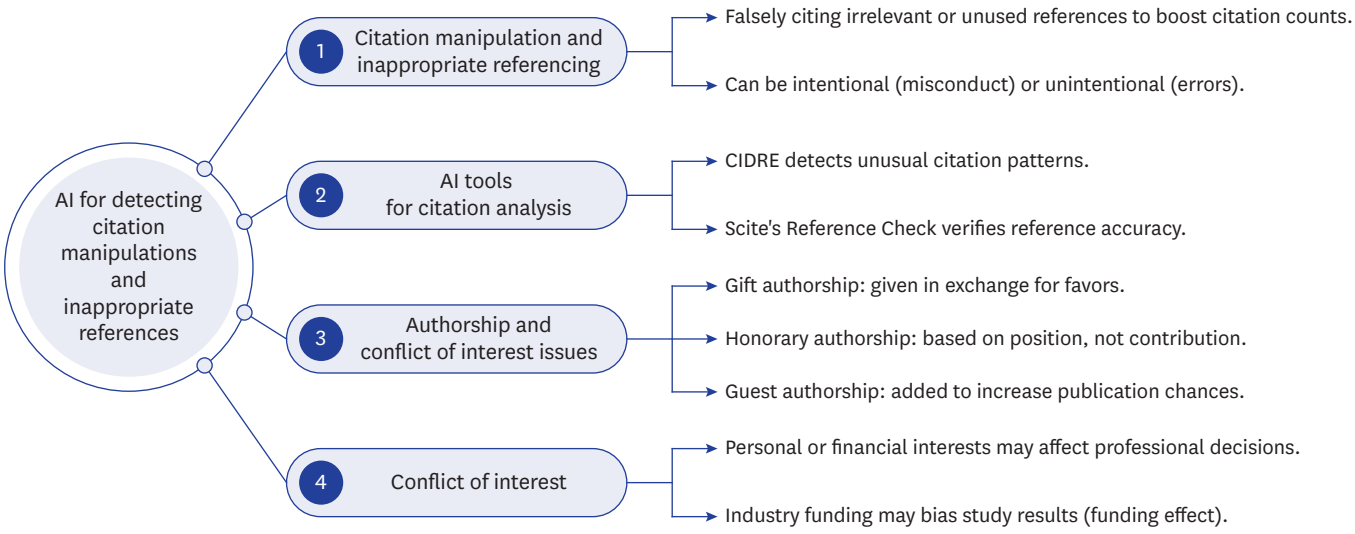

Fig. 1. AI for detecting citation manipulations and inappropriate references. 1: Citation manipulation and inappropriate referencing. 2: Conflict of interest. 3: AI tools for citation analysis. 4: Authorship and conflict of interest issues.
AI = artificial intelligence.

are available and used to detect anomalous writing behaviors such as SciDetect,[77] but its role in detecting authorship issues such as ghostwriting is still underreported (**Fig. 1**).

AI FOR DETECTING PLAGIARISM OF IDEAS, GRAPHICS, AND TEXTS

AI for detecting plagiarism of ideas, graphics, and texts

Plagiarism is using someone else's work without giving them credit. This work can be copied on an idea, method, data, or result. This work can be copied on an idea, method, data, or result.[78] There are multiple types of plagiarism, which are different in their characteristics and severity.[79] These types include direct plagiarism, which is considered a serious type of plagiarism where someone copies and publishes others' work and remix plagiarism, where someone rephrases and mic sentences from one or more sources.[79] The use of plagiarized content has been increasing over the past years, making the detection of such content crucial for academic integrity.[80]

AI tools for plagiarism detection

Previously, plagiarism detection was the sole responsibility of the editors and reviewers of academic journals, and the detection of academic theft was based on their experience.[81] Nowadays, plagiarism detection is done using computer software, making the detection process more sophisticated.[81] The available software programs differ in the database used, whether it is paid or free, the languages it can assess, and the file size limits it can analyze.[82] An example of the currently available AI-operated plagiarism detection tool is iThenticate, which is a paid and commonly used software by academic journals for the detection of plagiarism. This software has access to around 226,000 journals and more than 1,300 publishers worldwide,[81,83] and it used by large publishers, including Springer[80] and Elsevier.[84] Similar available platforms include Viper,[85] Turnitin,[86] Grammarly,[87] and Duplichecker.[88]

In scientific publishing, papers, including images and videos, are crucial components.[89] To ensure that these visual components remain intact, multiple AI-powered platforms are currently able to detect and search for graphical plagiarism, including ImageRights,[90] and TinEye, which is a reverse image searching image-searching platform.[91] Proofig AI is an AI-powered tool that is able to detect image alteration, manipulations, duplication and reuse, which is widely used by publishers including Elsevier, Springer, SAGE, Taylors and Francis, AACR, and others.[92] Proofig is utilized in science journals to detect any problematic graphical content submitted to journals. In case an abnormality is found, the authors will be contacted about the concerns. If they are unable to give a satisfactory explanation, this might cause their paper to be rejected.[36]

FUTURE DIRECTIONS AND CONCLUSIONS

Future studies should focus on enhancing AI tools that identify publication ethics concerning such authorship issues and conflicts of interest. Careful and appropriate use is crucial as AI becomes increasingly prevalent in editing processes.

Important lessons for researchers in their early careers include:

1. Keep in mind that while AI can assist, human evaluation is still essential.
2. Conflicts of interest and ethical clearances should always be disclosed in detail.
3. Avoid any unethical behaviors such as guest authoring and plagiarism.
4. Make use of AI tools to help your judgment, not to replace it.

In conclusion, AI has a great chance of strengthening the ethical standards of academic publishing. Effective use of AI tools may also benefit editorial teams and researchers, particularly when it comes to maintaining the integrity, fairness, and accuracy of academic writing.

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